46TH ANNIVERSARY

YOUTH UPRISINGS

A PURE AGENDA

ASSAM AGITATION, 1979-85

Assam

PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



▲ A 'rail roko' protest by AASU members in 1980

The six-year-long Assam agitation started with the primary demand for identification and deportation of illegal Bangladeshi immigrants residing in Assam. The agitation, led by the All Assam Students' Union (AASU) and the All Assam Gana Sangram Parishad (AAGSP), had begun as a non-violent movement. It turned violent in the later phases. Since the 1960s, there had been a demand in Assam for identification of illegal settlers, who were finding a place in the electoral rolls. The immediate trigger for the agitation was the discovery of over 45,000 illegal immigrants in the electoral rolls of the Mangaldoi Lok Sabha constituency in 1979. Over the next six years, Assam witnessed widespread civil disobedience, including railway blockades and attacks on oil pipelines, political instability and ethnic violence. While operations by security forces claimed the lives of over 850 student leaders, over 2,000 people were killed in the infamous Nellie and Khoirabari massacres in 1983. ■

–Kaushik Deka

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ALL IN ACCORD

The agitation ended on August 15, 1985 with the signing of the Assam Accord–a memorandum of settlement–between the Union government and the student leaders, who formed a political party, the Asom Gana Parishad, and won the next state assembly election with a massive mandate